

Automatic Problematic Thoughts and Corresponding Turn-Around Thoughts: Examples



Automatic Problematic Thought	Turn-Around Thought
Everyone should love me.	I would like it if everyone loved me, but I know that is impossible. Some people just don't get along and that's okay.
Every problem has an ideal solution.	Problems, by definition, are challenges without immediately obvious or ideal solutions. Problems often have best solutions, but rarely do they have ideal solutions.
I have to be highly competent in everything I do.	I would like to be competent in everything, but that is very unlikely. It also depends on my standards for competence. Is bowling a 150 score competent, or does it take 200 consistently to reach that standard? It is acceptable if I am competent at the things that matter most to me and merely okay at others.
Other people should always treat me considerately and fairly.	I would like that to happen, but people vary tremendously in the way they treat one another. People also vary in the way they will treat me based on how they feel on a particular day, level of stress, and other factors.
I must lose weight every week.	As a weight controller, I would like that, but this expectation is unrealistic. A wide variety of factors determine the number on the scale. The scale is an imperfect measure of effort. I can control the effort I put into my program and my consistency in key areas, at least to some extent. It is harder to control a number on a scale.
If I do not improve my fitness every week, then I am a failure—and I may as well give up.	I could use a much better standard to determine my success/failure than weekly improvements in fitness. I can evaluate my consistency of workouts and the degree to which I work hard at them. The process matters, too—not just the numbers on weights I lift or the speed of my runs.
If I do not succeed every week, then my wellness professional will think I am worthless, a failure, and uncommitted, so I may as well give up.	My wellness professional is there to support me, not to reject me for being imperfect. He or she will not view me as worthless because I struggle at this difficult task. That would be both mean and unreasonable.
If I do not eat the food my host offers, he or she will hate me.	Hosts do not care that much about what everyone eats. If someone were to hate me because of what I ate or did not eat, then I would not want that person for a friend anyway.